

Complex Prepositions

Quick Reference Guide

Complex prepositions are multi-word phrases that work like simple prepositions. They are more common in formal and professional English. This guide lists the most useful complex prepositions with their simpler everyday alternatives and an example for each.

Two-Word Prepositions

According to	People say / X says	<i>According to the report, sales increased by 10%.</i>
Due to	Because of	<i>The match was cancelled due to heavy rain.</i>
Apart from	Except for / Besides	<i>Apart from the dessert, the meal was wonderful.</i>
Ahead of	Before	<i>She arrived ahead of the deadline.</i>
Along with	Together with / With	<i>He sent the files along with a short note.</i>

Three-Word Prepositions

In spite of	Despite / Although	<i>In spite of the noise, she managed to sleep.</i>
In addition to	As well as / Besides	<i>In addition to English, he speaks two other languages.</i>
On behalf of	For / Representing	<i>She accepted the award on behalf of her team.</i>
In terms of	Regarding / About	<i>In terms of quality, this brand is the best.</i>
In favour of	Supporting / For	<i>The committee voted in favour of the new policy.</i>
By means of	Using / Through	<i>They raised money by means of a charity event.</i>

Multi-Word Prepositions (4+ Words)

As a result of	Because of	<i>As a result of the storm, many roads were closed.</i>
With the exception of	Except for	<i>With the exception of Jake, everyone passed the test.</i>
In the event of	If there is	<i>In the event of an emergency, call 999.</i>
With regard to	About / Concerning	<i>With regard to your question, I will reply by Friday.</i>

For the sake of	For / To help	<i>She moved abroad for the sake of her career.</i>

*Remember: Complex prepositions are followed by a noun, a noun phrase, or a verb-ing form — never by a full clause with a subject and verb. If you need a full clause, use the conjunction equivalent instead (e.g. use *although* instead of *in spite of*).*